SALES TRAINING DEBRIEF · SESSION 8

Know Your Numbers.
Sell the Process, Not the Product.

Session led by Corie Dawson, Director

Monday 18 May 2026 · Internal sales-team summary

The thesis in one line

Two failures showed up in the same pitch this session: the rep didn't know the price points cold, and the rep sold the website (product) instead of the build experience (process). Either failure on its own kills a deal. Both together — guaranteed. Conviction comes from owning your numbers and your process so deeply you can be questioned for an hour without flinching. That depth is the only thing that produces the kind of unshakeable energy nothing can knock out of the room.

> *"You're selling websites, boys. The website has nothing to do with it. You're selling the process — and you don't know your process well enough to defend it."*
> — Corie

1. Know your numbers cold

The session opened with a rep being asked the starting price of a tier and not being able to recall it. That single moment told the prospect everything they needed to know: this person doesn't know their own offer. The rest of the pitch was over before it started.

> *"There's a reason the guy didn't sign up. You didn't know your numbers. He could tell."* — Corie

What "knowing your numbers" actually means

You have five products. Five. If you can't recite every price point, every page count, and what each package includes — you don't know your product. The customer's test is much harder than that: they will compare you to a competitor, ask why you cost what you cost, and probe what changes between tiers. If you have to look anything up, your authority is gone.

The minimum bar by Friday this week

- Memorise the five price points to the dollar — including standard discount.
- Memorise the page count and inclusions for each tier.
- Be able to explain why each price point is what it is, in one sentence.
- Map turnover bands to recommended tier — service business and trade business.
- Drill it with a colleague. Get them to pick a tier at random and have you describe it.

The four months we spent designing the pricing matrix is the reason it makes sense. The hours you spend memorising it now is the reason you'll close.

2. Sell the process, not the product

The team's current default is to pitch the website itself — the design, the platform, the look. That's a losing position, because any competitor can copy a look, and a DIY platform can produce something visually fine. The unique thing we sell isn't the website. It's the build experience.

> *"Whether it's built on a DIY site or not, I'd keep the price as is. It's never been about the technology. It's about the process of getting their ideas into a reality with very slick execution — where they have very little to do."* — Corie (paraphrased)

The five-step process to walk every prospect through

1. Discovery call with the project lead (Taylor) — pre-built question set, no homework on the client.
2. Handover meeting with the strategist (Claire) — already fully prepped, gets straight into building.
3. Visual styling — the prospect picks from a stamped pitch of themes/icons/colours, like choosing finishes for a renovation.
4. Build phase — we do the work; the client receives staged previews.
5. Launch and handover — including hosting, training, and post-launch support.

Why this works

The website is the visible product, but it's like a finished bathroom — most of the quality lives behind the wall. The prospect can't see why we're better just looking at end products. What they can see, and what they buy, is the process that gets them there with minimum stress. Drill the five steps until you can explain them in 90 seconds without notes.

3. Read the room before pitching high

"Always pitch high" (Session 1) is a rule of thumb — not a rigid script. Pitching high without first reading the situation can backfire badly. The rep this session led with the most expensive tier on a prospect doing ~$1.2M turnover who was booked out nine months — and got brought back down so far the deal almost died.

What "reading the room" actually means

- Turnover. What does the math say they can comfortably afford?
- Booking position. Are they hungry for leads (light book) or already maxed (booked solid)?
- Stated intent. Are they scaling up, holding steady, or winding down?

- Visible signals. No website, basic Facebook page, no marketing investment ever → they're not high-spend buyers, but they're ready to start somewhere.

The fix — opinion-positioning with cotton wool both sides

Instead of leading with the top tier and dropping later (which feels like retreat), show two adjacent tiers, form a soft opinion, and put cotton wool on both sides:

> *""I've got two I think suit you — the silver at $X and the gold at $Y. I don't think we need to look at the diamond, that's overkill. Between these two, I'm leaning toward gold because of the projects page — but have a look and tell me what you think.""*

You've formed an opinion (conviction), but you've left room to move in either direction (cotton wool). The prospect feels guided, not pushed. If they wobble, you can move down without losing face. If they're keen, you can move up without seeming greedy.

4. Handling the DIY / cheaper-platform objection

Almost every pitch will hit a version of: "my mate can do it on Squarespace / Wix / Shopify for $2,000." Most reps panic-pitch their product features when this comes up. That's the wrong move — features are exactly what the cheap platform also has.

The right reframe

> *""Squarespace is a great DIY platform. So is Wix. So is half a dozen others. If you want to build it yourself, you absolutely can — that's why it's so cheap. There's no skill required. It's like DIY plumbing. Now — do you actually have the time to build this yourself? Because the work doesn't vanish on a cheap platform. It moves to you. You're booked out for six months. You're also going to write all the content yourself, sort the images, do the SEO setup, manage the hosting…""*

Why this works

- You don't denigrate the platform — you agree with it. Acknowledging the truth gives you authority.
- You shift the question from "platform vs platform" to "your time vs ours."
- You leverage what you already know about them (booked out, busy, no website yet → no spare hours).
- You make the cheap option visible as work-they-have-to-do — which is the part they were hoping to avoid.

Bonus line for when they mention their mate: "And honestly — most of our clients come from rebuilds. They went cheap first. The website they're paying us to fix is the second one they've paid for. We're not the cheapest. But we're usually the last one you'll need."

5. The double-whammy — asymmetric attack on competitors

A specific technique from the session: when a prospect raises a competitor's advantage, agree with the surface point AND undercut it in the same breath. You appear fair, your competitor gets damaged anyway.

The pattern

> *“"Yes, our websites look better than theirs. And honestly, they're using a DIY platform that isn't industry standard. But neither of those is actually your problem. The real problem is the process — and that's what you're actually buying from us."”*

Why it lands

- You're not arguing with the prospect — you're agreeing with their observations. That builds trust.
- You've made the competitor's strengths irrelevant ("neither of those is your problem").
- You've elevated your offer above the comparison entirely ("the real problem is something else").
- Asymmetric: regardless of which competitor point they raise, you can use the same structure.

> *“I'm not putting it down. I'm saying yeah, I recognise you, and I'm meeting you here — then whammy, that's not even your real problem.”* — Corie

6. Time travel — build a database of objection moves

A reframe Corie returned to throughout the session: every objection you'll face has already been faced. The reps who close consistently aren't smarter — they've built a personal database of "if-they-say-X, I-say-Y" responses. They time-travel by recognising patterns from previous calls.

> *“Capture every situation. In three months, in six months, in two weeks, the same situation will arrive — but this time you'll know what to do.”* — Corie

How to actually build the database

- After every pitch (won or lost), write down the one or two objections that surprised you.
- Workshop the response with a colleague within 48 hours, while it's fresh.
- Add the move to your personal playbook. Don't trust your memory — write it down.
- Drill it out loud with a colleague before your next pitch.
- Review the playbook once a week. The same six or eight objections drive 80% of lost deals.

The judo parallel

A black belt doesn't handle every position by improvising — they handle every position they've already trained for hundreds of times. They don't look fast in the moment because their brain is fast. They look fast because the move was already burned in. Sales works identically.

7. Offense beats defense — every time

A clear pattern in the failed pitch this session: the rep started offensive (their pitch, their order, their pace) but went defensive the moment the prospect pushed back. From that point on, every reply was a justification, every move was a retreat, and the close was inevitable — for the prospect, not for us.

Defensive (losing)	Offensive (winning)
Wait for the objection, then handle it	Predict the objection and pre-empt it
Justify your price when challenged	Reframe their challenge ("the platform isn't your real problem")
Match their pace once they slow down	Hold your pace and let them catch up
"Are you happy to proceed?"	"I'll send the proposal. Sign the DocuSign when you're ready."
Soften when they push back hard	Stay grounded; reframe; restate; move on

> *“Defense in sales is just trying to survive. That's not a winning strategy. You step into a sales conversation like you step into a ring — you go forward, or you go home.”* — Corie (paraphrased)

8. "Where do I need to be?" — the closing power question

When the prospect is wobbling but engaged, deploy a specific line that does several things at once: confirms your interest in their business, transfers control of the price conversation, and qualifies them in or out cleanly.

> *“"I want your business. Realistically — where do I need to be? You know I can't get to $2,000. But where do we need to be? Be straight — I can only say no if it's outlandish, and that'll be the end of it. So tell me what you actually want from me."”*

What's happening in the line

- **"I want your business" —** direct, clean, no apologies. Most reps never actually say this.
- **"Realistically" —** signals you're not asking for a fantasy number. Pre-empts time-wasting.

- **"You know I can't get to $2,000" —** rules out the bottom of the range without you having to argue.
- **"I can only say no if it's outlandish" —** gives you the right to walk. Asymmetric: either they name a reasonable number or they qualify themselves out.
- **"What do you want from me?" —** transfers responsibility for the next move to them.

What happens next

One of three things. Either they name a reasonable price (you go to the office, return with a close-out number, close). Or they name something outlandish (you decline cleanly — "that's not workable for us, but thanks for your time"). Or they refuse to name anything ("I'll think about it"). The third response is itself a qualification: a prospect who can't name a number when invited to wasn't buying anyway.

9. Handling "don't pressure me" gracefully

Some prospects, when they feel the close coming, deploy "don't pressure me" as a defence. The instinct is to back off and apologise. That's the wrong move — you reinforce that asking direct questions is "pressure," which kills future conversation.

The reframe

> *""I do apologise if it's come across as pressure — that's not the intention. What I am trying to do is get a straight answer from you, and I think with the time we've spent together, that's fair. So when you're ready to give me one — give me a call.""*

What this does

- Acknowledges their concern without conceding ground.
- Reframes your "pressure" as professional follow-through — which it is.
- Hands the next move back to them, but on your terms.
- Preserves your authority for the eventual follow-up call.

Most prospects, hearing this, will immediately give you the straight answer they were avoiding. The line is uncomfortable to deliver until you've done it three or four times — then it becomes one of the most useful tools in your kit.

10. "Teryitis" — the credibility tax of overstating everything

A named failure pattern Corie called out: the habit of describing everything as the best, the greatest, the most amazing. "Best sandwich I've ever had." "This is going to be epic." "Greatest applicant ever." When you over-state routinely, your hits stop landing — because your average is already at maximum.

Teryitis (overstating)	Calibrated (credible)
"This is the best song I've ever heard."	"I think you'll like this — could be a banger."
"This applicant is the strongest we've ever seen."	"This one's the most promising of the batch."
"That sandwich was incredible."	"That was a really good sandwich."
Always 10/10 — no credibility on any 10/10.	Mostly 7s and 8s — 10s land with impact.

Why this matters for sales

Your customers pattern-match your credibility too. If every applicant you describe to your manager is "amazing," your manager's ability to spot a genuinely strong one is gone. Same with your prospects — if every product feature is "the best," none of them stand out. Hedge slightly when you're uncertain, and let your genuine 10/10s carry weight.

> *"I never overstate anything, but I get real close and I stretch it as far as I can within reason. That's the difference. The entire conversation is high credibility, high conviction, delivering at every point. Believable language. People can hear the difference."* — Corie

11. Price is a communication — own where you sit

Price isn't just a number — it's a message. The team has been treating cheap competitors as a threat. They're not. They're the contrast that makes our positioning visible.

The airline example

A flight from Singapore to Vietnam: Singapore Airlines $400. VietJet $200. Even with $200 of savings on the table, most travellers will still pick Singapore Airlines — because the price difference IS the message. Cheap signals risk. Expensive signals safety. The customer pays the premium for the implied promise that you'll get there safely, on time, and with your luggage.

Translating to our pitch

- When a prospect says "I can get this for $2,000," that's confirmation we're positioned correctly — not a threat.
- A $2,000 website signals risk: cheap platform, no support, DIY build, no professional process.
- Our price signals: professional process, real support, no DIY work for you, results that hold up.
- The pro response to "$2,000 from my mate" isn't to defend our price — it's to elevate our positioning: "That's exactly why we exist. We're the people you call after the $2,000 website didn't deliver."

> *"A $2,000 website is a communication. It's telling the customer: low effort, low experience, fix-it-yourself. Our price is a communication too. Don't be afraid of being more expensive — own it."* — Corie (paraphrased)

12. Behaviours to change this week

6. **Memorise the five price points by Friday.** No prompt, no looking. If a colleague picks a tier at random, you describe price, page count, inclusions, and ideal-fit customer in under 30 seconds.
7. **Drill the five-step process.** Be able to walk a prospect through it in 90 seconds without notes. The process is what we sell.
8. **Read the room before pitching the top tier.** Turnover, booking position, intent. Match the tier to the situation, not to the template.
9. **Build your objection database.** Write down every objection that surprised you on a pitch. Workshop the response within 48 hours.
10. **Use the double-whammy on competitor objections.** Agree with their surface point. Then undercut it. Then elevate above the comparison.
11. **Deploy "where do I need to be?" on wobbly prospects.** Practise the line. Use it at least twice this week.
12. **Handle "don't pressure me" gracefully.** Apologise softly, reframe as professional follow-up, hand the next move back. Don't collapse.
13. **Audit your overstatement.** Catch yourself the next time you use "best," "greatest," "amazing." Calibrate. Save the 10s for real 10s.

Final reminder. The customer can tell when you don't know your numbers. They can tell when you're pitching the product instead of the process. They can tell when you're defending instead of attacking. None of this is hidden from them. The work this week is to close all three gaps — and the prospects you couldn't close last month will close themselves the second time around.